The use of motion constructions in L2 Spanish: Tracing effects of input- and learner-related factors

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Introduction

Expressing motion or how an object's physical location shifts from one point to another in space (e.g., saltar la valla 'jump over the fence') constitutes a well-known learning difficulty for L2 speakers due to cross-linguistic differences (Cadierno, 2020; Hijazo-Gascón, 2021). However, because most previous research has investigated this question cross-sectionally, very little is known about the ways in which L2 learners' expression of motion emerges and changes over time, including potential roles for input- and learner-related factors. The current study addresses this need by examining (i) how L2 speakers learn to express motion over time and (ii) how various input- and learner-related factors influence this process.

Research Questions

1. How does L2 Spanish learners' use of motion constructions change over time?
2. To what extent do input-related variables, including frequency and verb-construction association strength, influence L2 use of motion constructions over time?
3. To what extent do learner-related variables, including proficiency, engagement, use, social network size, influence L2 use of motion constructions over time?

Methodology

- Longitudinal design with four data collection points over a 16-week-long semester

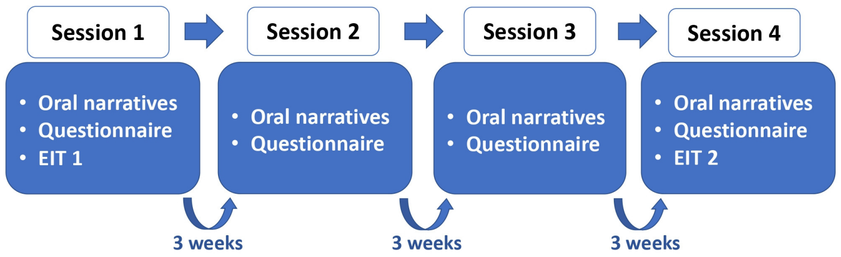
Participants

- 31 L1 English learners of Spanish enrolled in basic Spanish language courses in five universities in the US

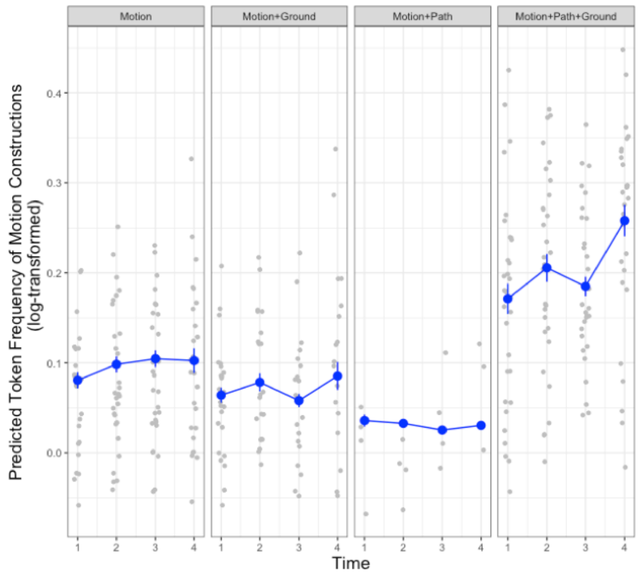
Data collection instruments:

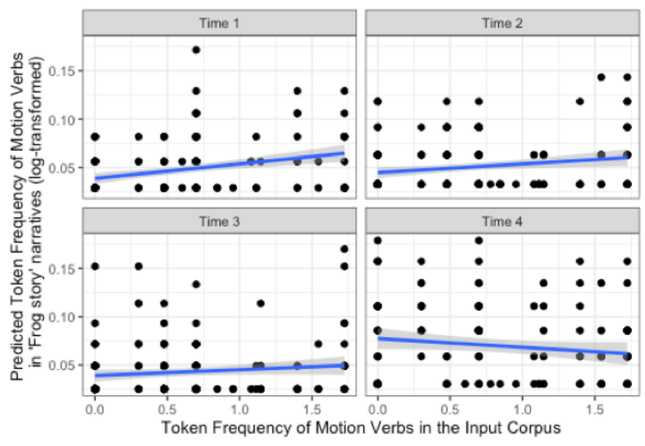
- Picture-based narrative task
- Spanish Elicited Imitation Task (Ortega et al., 1999)
- Language Engagement and Social Networks Questionnaire (McManus, 2019)
- Prototypicality Rating Test
- Input corpus consisting of print- and video-based instructional materials

Procedure



Results





Discussion and Conclusions

- There were distinct and nonlinear patterns of change for different motion constructions
- Input frequency was found to be a significant predictor for L2 use of motion constructions
- L2 learners used fewer high-frequency constructions over time
- No significant effect of other input-related (association strength and semantic prototypicality) and individual (L2 proficiency, engagement, use, and network size) variables on the frequency of L2 use of motion constructions was observed
- L2 constructional development is a non-linear process associated with both progress and attrition
- L2 learners appear to rely on statistical information in the input (mainly frequency) when learning L2-based motion constructions
- Findings revealed the importance of examining both group trends and individual learning trajectories to get a multifaceted picture of L2 constructional development over time

Selected References

1. Cadierno, A. (2020). Thinking for speaking in an L2: From research findings to pedagogical implications. In W. Lowie, M. Michel, M. Keijzer, & R. Steinkrauss (Eds.), Usage-Based Dynamics in Second Language Development (pp. 7–28). Multilingual Matters.
2. Hijazo-Gascón, A. (2021). Moving across languages: Motion events in Spanish as a second language. De Gruyter Mouton.
3. McManus, K. (2019). Relationships between social networks and language development during study abroad. Language, Culture and Curriculum, 32(3), 270-284.

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